playing senior men's cricket for Western Province. It all happened very quickly. Way *too* quickly, when I think back now.

I played my first-ever premier-league club game for Avondale against Tech-Mutual, and this was a time when club cricket in South Africa was at its strongest, with every club having at least one or two provincial players in their line-ups. I managed to score a 100 that day. This really made the headlines – 'schoolboy prodigy scores ton in first premier club game' – and the next thing I get called up into the Western Province B-team.

I played one game for them – against Transvaal B at Newlands over 10–12 December 1990, scoring 77 runs – and the next week I was invited to the A-team practice. I remember seeing the coach talking to some of the Province players and watching them just shake their heads before walking away. I knew then that they were going to pick me for the next game, but it also meant one of the established players would have to make way, which understandably pissed them off. And so I became the youngest guy in 130 years to play for Province. Clearly the coach, Hylton Ackerman, liked what he saw in me.

I wasn't so sure though.

I didn't share his confidence in my cricket. I knew there was a huge difference between facing schoolboy bowlers and facing the men in Currie Cup cricket. It was like chalk and cheese. South African cricket in the late 1980s and early 1990s consisted of a crop of 20 or so bowlers who could all have played international cricket. Apart from the aforementioned Bosch, Donald and Schultz, you also had the likes of Rudi Bryson, Steve Elworthy, Chris van Noordwyk, Corrie van Zyl, Nico Pretorius, Brendon Fourie, Simon Base, Russell Adams, Adrian Holdstock and Dean Payne, to name but a few. All these okes were genuinely quick. I kakked off against them, and my fear of getting badly hit was huge.

The only experience I'd had that even approached facing bowlers of this calibre was playing a warm-up game for the Western Province Nuffield XI against an invitational Mellville XI, made up of senior players. The match took place at the Cape Town Cricket Club. The Mellville XI had a quickie called Les Ryan, who came steaming in and hit me on the helmet, right on the badge. I remember him glaring at me and saying, 'Welcome to the big league, boet.'

But even that was nothing compared to A-section Currie Cup cricket for Western Province. My performance reflected my concerns. In that first year